

Traditional Indian System of Medicine

AVP- Amrita value programme

Introduction to Indian Traditional Healing Systems

India is home to some of the oldest holistic healing systems in the world. Among these, **Ayurveda, Siddha, Naturopathy, and Acupuncture** are recognized for their natural approaches to health, focusing on the balance of body, mind, and spirit. These systems emphasize prevention, lifestyle modification, and the body's innate ability to heal itself.

2. Historical Origins

- **Ayurveda** originated around 3000 BCE from the Vedas, especially the *Atharva Veda*.
- **Siddha** medicine emerged in South India, credited to the ancient Tamil sages called *Siddhars*.
- **Naturopathy** gained formal structure in the 19th century but has roots in Indian yogic and nature-based practices.
- **Acupuncture**, though of Chinese origin, has been integrated into Indian alternative medicine in recent decades.

Ayurveda and Siddha Systems

3. Fundamental Principles of Ayurveda

Ayurveda is based on the **Pancha Mahabhuta** (five great elements):

- *Prithvi* (Earth), *Ap* (Water), *Tejas* (Fire), *Vayu* (Air), and *Akasha* (Space). These combine to form the **Tridoshas**—*Vata*, *Pitta*, and *Kapha*—which govern all physiological and psychological processes. Balance among doshas maintains health; imbalance causes disease.

4. Diagnostic Methods in Ayurveda

Ayurvedic diagnosis involves:

- **Darshana** (observation),
- **Sparsana** (palpation), and
- **Prashna** (interrogation).
Pulse reading (*Nadi Pariksha*), tongue, eyes, and urine examination are also key tools to assess doshic balance.

5. Ayurvedic Treatment Modalities

Treatment aims to restore balance through:

- **Shodhana (purification)** – e.g., *Panchakarma* (five cleansing procedures).
- **Shamana (pacification)** – herbal medicines, diet regulation, and lifestyle changes.
- **Rasayana (rejuvenation)** – tonics for vitality and longevity.
- **Ahar (diet)** and **Vihar (conduct)** are central to maintaining doshic harmony.

6. Siddha System – The Tamil Tradition

The Siddha system is one of India's oldest medical traditions, practiced mainly in Tamil Nadu. It integrates medicine, alchemy, yoga, and spirituality. The philosophy mirrors Ayurveda but emphasizes **96 tattvas** (principles of human existence) and aims at attaining **perfection (siddhi)** of the body and mind.

7. Siddha Diagnostic and Treatment Principles

Diagnosis in Siddha considers **environmental, dietary, and psychological** factors.

Treatment categories include:

- **Maruthuvam** (medicine using herbs, minerals, and metals)
 - **Thokkanam** (therapeutic massage)
 - **Yoga and Meditation**
 - **Diet therapy** and **Kayakalpa** (rejuvenation therapy).
- Siddha medicine strongly emphasizes lifestyle discipline and preventive care.

Naturopathy and Acupuncture

8. Philosophy of Naturopathy

Naturopathy believes that **nature is the greatest healer**. The human body has an inherent self-healing power. Disease is seen as the body's attempt to eliminate toxins and restore balance. Treatment supports natural processes without drugs or surgery.

9. Principles and Techniques of Naturopathy

Core principles include:

- *Do no harm (Primum non nocere)*
 - *Treat the cause, not the symptom*
 - *Doctor as teacher*
 - *Prevention is better than cure.*
- Common methods:
- Hydrotherapy (water treatments)
 - Mud therapy
 - Fasting and diet therapy
 - Massage and chromotherapy
 - Sunbaths and air baths

- Yoga and meditation.
A balanced diet, pure air, sunlight, and exercise are viewed as essential components of health.

10. Role of Diet and Detoxification

Naturopathy advocates **whole, plant-based foods**, minimal processing, and fasting for detoxification. The diet is tailored to individual constitution, climatic conditions, and the nature of illness. Fasting helps eliminate accumulated toxins and rejuvenates body functions.

11. Integration with Modern Medicine

Naturopathy is now recognized under **AYUSH** (Ayurveda, Yoga, Unani, Siddha, and Homeopathy) by the Government of India. Many wellness centers combine naturopathy with modern diagnostics and physiotherapy to enhance treatment effectiveness.

12. Acupuncture – Energy Medicine

Acupuncture, derived from **Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM)**, has gained wide acceptance in India as a complementary therapy. It is based on the concept of **Qi (vital energy)** flowing through channels called **meridians**. Blockages or imbalances in Qi cause disease.

Integration, Research & Modern Relevance

13. Mechanism and Application of Acupuncture

Fine needles are inserted into specific points on the body to correct imbalances in Qi. This stimulates the nervous system, enhances circulation, and triggers the release of endorphins. Acupuncture is widely used for:

- Pain management (arthritis, migraine, back pain)
 - Stress and anxiety
 - Digestive and respiratory disorders
 - Rehabilitation therapy.
- In India, acupuncture is practiced by certified professionals under AYUSH and medical councils.

14. Integration of Traditional Systems

India promotes **integrated medicine**, combining traditional and modern approaches. Ayurvedic and Siddha physicians collaborate with allopathic practitioners in government hospitals and wellness centers. The **National AYUSH Mission (NAM)** supports research, education, and public awareness about these systems.

15. Global Recognition and Future Prospects

Ayurveda and Siddha have gained international recognition as holistic systems emphasizing prevention and lifestyle medicine. Naturopathy and acupuncture are increasingly incorporated

into wellness resorts and medical tourism. Continued research, quality assurance, and standardized education are vital to maintain authenticity and global trust.

Ayurveda

1. Introduction

Ayurveda, the ancient system of Indian medicine, is derived from the Sanskrit words “*Ayus*” (life) and “*Veda*” (knowledge). Thus, Ayurveda literally means “*the science of life*.” It originated more than 5,000 years ago and forms part of the *Atharva Veda*. Ayurveda does not merely focus on curing disease but emphasizes **the balance between body, mind, soul, and environment** as the foundation of health.

Ayurveda’s approach is holistic, preventive, and curative. It promotes a way of living that maintains harmony with nature through correct diet, lifestyle, mental discipline, and the use of natural substances.

2. The Aim of Ayurveda

The primary goal of Ayurveda is described in classical texts as:

“*Swasthasya swasthya rakshanam, aturasya vikara prashamanam ca.*”
Meaning – “To maintain the health of the healthy and to cure the ailments of the sick.”

Hence, equal importance is given to **preserving health** and **treating diseases**.

3. Philosophical Foundations

Ayurveda is based on certain universal principles that explain the relationship between the body and the cosmos:

- **Pancha Mahabhuta (Five Great Elements):**
Everything in the universe, including the human body, is composed of
 1. *Prithvi* (Earth) – solidity, structure
 2. *Ap* (Water) – cohesion, fluidity
 3. *Tejas* (Fire) – transformation, metabolism
 4. *Vayu* (Air) – movement
 5. *Akasha* (Ether) – space, communication
- **Tridosha Theory:**
The five elements combine to form three functional energies or **Doshas**:
 - **Vata (Air + Ether):** governs motion, circulation, respiration

- **Pitta (Fire + Water):** governs metabolism, digestion, energy
- **Kapha (Water + Earth):** governs structure, lubrication, immunity

Each person is born with a unique balance of these doshas, called **Prakriti** (constitution). Imbalance among doshas leads to disease.

Structure, Diagnosis, and Treatment Philosophy

4. The Concept of Health and Disease

Health (*Swasthya*) in Ayurveda is a **balanced state** of Doshas, Dhatus (tissues), Agni (digestive fire), Malas (wastes), and a peaceful mind and soul.

Disease (*Vyadhi*) arises when there is imbalance or disturbance in any of these components due to improper diet, lifestyle, stress, or environmental changes.

5. Diagnostic Methods (Rogi Pareeksha)

Ayurvedic diagnosis is personalized. The physician studies both the **patient (Rogi)** and the **disease (Roga)** through:

- **Darshana (Inspection):** observing the body, skin, eyes, tongue, posture.
- **Sparshana (Palpation):** checking pulse (*Nadi Pariksha*), temperature, and touch.
- **Prashna (Questioning):** gathering patient history, habits, and symptoms.

Other assessments include urine, stool, and tongue examination, along with understanding the patient's mental and emotional state.

6. The Eight Branches of Ayurveda (Ashtanga Ayurveda)

1. **Kaya Chikitsa** – Internal medicine
2. **Bala Chikitsa** – Pediatrics
3. **Graha Chikitsa** – Psychiatry and spiritual therapy
4. **Urdhvanga Chikitsa** – ENT and ophthalmology
5. **Shalya Tantra** – Surgery
6. **Shalakya Tantra** – Diseases above the shoulders
7. **Agada Tantra** – Toxicology
8. **Rasayana & Vajikarana** – Rejuvenation and reproductive health

These eight branches reflect Ayurveda's scientific comprehensiveness, covering prevention, treatment, and rejuvenation.

7. Basic Treatment Philosophy

Ayurveda follows two major treatment approaches:

- **Shodhana (Purification Therapy):** aims to eliminate toxins from the body and restore doshic balance.
- **Shamana (Palliative Therapy):** pacifies aggravated doshas through herbs, diet, and lifestyle corrections.

In addition, Ayurveda emphasizes **Rasayana (rejuvenation)** to enhance vitality, longevity, and immunity.

Therapeutic Practices and Modern Relevance

8. Panchakarma – The Purification Therapy

Panchakarma is a unique Ayurvedic detoxification and rejuvenation program consisting of five major procedures:

1. **Vamana** – Therapeutic emesis (vomiting) to expel toxins from the upper body.
2. **Virechana** – Purgation to cleanse the liver and intestines.
3. **Basti** – Medicated enema to balance Vata and remove toxins from the colon.
4. **Nasya** – Nasal administration of medicines to cleanse head and sinuses.
5. **Raktamokshana** – Bloodletting for purification and treating skin or blood disorders.

These therapies are preceded by **Purva Karma** (preparatory measures like oil massage and steam) and followed by **Paschat Karma** (post-care and diet regulation).

9. Ayurvedic Medicines and Herbs

Ayurvedic formulations are mainly plant-based, supplemented with minerals and natural substances.

Common preparations include:

- **Kashayam** (decoctions)
- **Arishtam** (fermented tonics)
- **Churnam** (powders)
- **Lehyam** (herbal pastes)
- **Tailam** (medicated oils)

Popular herbs: **Ashwagandha, Tulsi, Turmeric, Triphala, Brahmi, Neem, Guduchi**, etc.—each supporting specific doshic balance and organ health.

10. Diet and Lifestyle (Ahara and Vihara)

Ayurveda gives paramount importance to **Ahara (food)** and **Vihara (daily routine)**.

- Food should be **fresh, seasonal, balanced**, and suited to one's constitution.
- Eating at regular times, in moderate quantity, and with mindfulness is advised.
- **Dinacharya (daily routine)** includes waking before sunrise, exercise, oil massage (*Abhyanga*), meditation, and regular sleep.
- **Ritucharya (seasonal regimen)** helps adapt lifestyle to seasonal variations.

11. Rasayana and Rejuvenation Therapy

Rasayana Chikitsa promotes longevity, memory, youthfulness, and immunity. It includes:

- Herbal tonics like *Chyawanprash*
- Balanced nutrition and meditation
- Yoga and pranayama for physical and mental rejuvenation

12. Modern Relevance and Global Recognition

Today, Ayurveda is recognized worldwide as a **complementary and alternative medical system**.

Institutions under India's **Ministry of AYUSH** promote education, research, and clinical application. Ayurveda contributes significantly to **wellness tourism, preventive medicine, and lifestyle management** globally. Its principles of individualized care, natural healing, and harmony with nature align well with modern integrative medicine.

Understanding Organic Food Habits in India

1. Introduction

Organic food habits represent a return to India's ancient way of life — eating fresh, natural, and minimally processed foods produced without chemicals or artificial additives. The word “*organic*” refers to food grown through **natural farming methods**, using compost, bio-fertilizers, crop rotation, and pest-repellent plants rather than synthetic fertilizers or pesticides.

In India, organic food is not new; it is a **revival of traditional agricultural wisdom** practiced for centuries before the industrialization of farming. Ayurveda and traditional Indian diets have always emphasized food that is “*satvik*” — pure, fresh, light, and in harmony with nature.

2. Principles of Organic Eating

Organic food habits are based on the following principles:

1. **Natural Origin:** Foods cultivated through eco-friendly methods without chemical fertilizers, pesticides, or genetically modified seeds.
2. **Seasonal Consumption:** Eating fruits, vegetables, and grains that grow naturally in the current season to maintain balance with environmental changes.
3. **Local Sourcing:** Consuming locally grown produce reduces transportation time, preserves freshness, and supports local farmers.
4. **Minimal Processing:** Preference for whole grains, unpolished rice, raw jaggery, cold-pressed oils, and stone-ground flours rather than refined products.
5. **Sustainability:** Organic agriculture maintains soil fertility, water purity, and biodiversity.

3. Traditional Indian Organic Foods

Indian kitchens have long practiced organic living through simple daily habits:

- **Millets** like *ragi*, *bajra*, and *jowar* were staples before polished rice became common.
- **Cow-based agriculture** with dung and urine used as natural manure and pesticide.
- **Home gardening** and “*Thottam*” (kitchen gardens) for vegetables and herbs.
- **Fermented foods** like *idli*, *dosa*, *curd*, and *pickles* — prepared naturally without preservatives.
- **Ghee**, *cold-pressed oils*, and *jaggery* formed integral parts of the traditional organic diet.

4. Levels of Cooking: Raw, Half-Cooked, and Fully Cooked

Indian dietary tradition classifies food not only by ingredients but also by **its cooking level** and **digestive impact**.

a) Raw or Uncooked Foods (Amanita / Asamskrita Ahara)

These include fruits, nuts, seeds, sprouted grains, salads, and raw vegetables.

- **Benefits:** High in enzymes, vitamins, fiber, and life energy (*prana*).
- **Examples:** Sprouted mung beans, cucumber, tender coconut, papaya, soaked almonds.
- **Ayurvedic View:** Raw foods are *cooling* and beneficial in hot climates but may reduce digestive fire (*agni*) if taken excessively or at night.

b) Half-Cooked or Lightly Cooked Foods (Ardha-Paka Ahara)

Lightly steamed or sautéed foods preserve nutrients while making them easier to digest.

- **Examples:** Lightly steamed vegetables, boiled lentils, semi-cooked rice (*kanji*), sautéed greens.

- **Benefits:** Balanced nutrition, improved taste, better assimilation.
- **Cultural Context:** Many fasting or detox diets in India use half-cooked or mildly processed food for internal cleansing.

c) Fully Cooked Foods (Paka Ahara)

These are traditional cooked dishes that form the main part of Indian meals.

- **Examples:** Rice, dal, chapati, khichdi, cooked vegetables, soups, and stews.
- **Benefits:** Easy digestion, palatable, suitable for all ages.
- **Ayurvedic View:** Fully cooked, freshly prepared food is *satvik* and enhances strength, clarity, and longevity.

Ayurveda advises avoiding **reheated or stale food**, as it loses its life force and may generate toxins (*ama*) in the body.

5. Benefits of Organic Food Habits

1. **Better Nutrition:** Organic fruits and vegetables contain higher levels of antioxidants and essential minerals.
2. **Chemical-Free:** Reduces exposure to harmful pesticides and preservatives.
3. **Improved Digestion:** Fresh and naturally cooked food supports a healthy gut microbiome.
4. **Environmental Health:** Organic farming conserves soil and water, reducing pollution.
5. **Ethical Living:** Supports animal welfare and sustainable livelihoods for small farmers.

6. Indian Movements and Certification

The Government of India, through the **Ministry of Agriculture**, promotes organic farming via:

- **Paramparagat Krishi Vikas Yojana (PKVY)**
- **National Programme for Organic Production (NPOP)**
- **FSSAI's Jaivik Bharat Logo** to identify certified organic products.

7. Organic Food and Ayurveda

Ayurveda classifies food into *Satvik* (pure), *Rajasik* (stimulating), and *Tamasik* (dulling).

- **Satvik foods** — freshly cooked organic grains, milk, fruits, vegetables, and nuts — nourish both body and mind.

- **Rajasik foods** (spicy, salty, fried) and **Tamasik foods** (stale, processed, frozen) are discouraged for daily consumption.

Eating organic and freshly cooked meals in a peaceful environment supports mental clarity and emotional stability — essential components of holistic health.

8. Practical Guidelines for an Organic Lifestyle

1. Prefer **home-cooked food** using traditional utensils (earthen pots, iron pans).
2. Eat **freshly prepared meals**; avoid microwaved or preserved food.
3. Include a **portion of raw salad or fruit** daily.
4. Buy from **local organic farmers** or certified sources.
5. Practice **mindful eating** — eat slowly, with gratitude.

50 Important Ayurvedic Medicinal Plants of India

A concise 5-page summary of 50 commonly used Ayurvedic medicinal plants in Kerala and other parts of India. Each entry lists the common name, botanical name, parts used, primary actions/properties, and main traditional uses.

1. **Ashwagandha** — *Withania somnifera* | Parts: root, leaves
 - Actions: Adaptogen, nervine tonic, rejuvenative.
 - Uses: Stress, chronic fatigue, low immunity, male reproductive health, as a general rasayana.
2. **Tulsi (Holy Basil)** — *Ocimum sanctum* | Parts: leaves
 - Actions: Antimicrobial, antipyretic, adaptogen, expectorant.
 - Uses: Respiratory infections, fever, immunity support, digestive complaints, stress relief.
3. **Turmeric (Haridra)** — *Curcuma longa* | Parts: rhizome
 - Actions: Anti-inflammatory, antioxidant, hepatoprotective.
 - Uses: Wound healing, joint pain, liver support, skin conditions, digestive complaints.
4. **Neem** — *Azadirachta indica* | Parts: leaves, bark, oil
 - Actions: Antiseptic, antimicrobial, blood purifier.
 - Uses: Skin disorders, parasitic infections, dental care, topical applications for wounds.

5. **Amla (Amalaki)** — *Phyllanthus emblica* | Parts: fruit
 - Actions: Rich in vitamin C, antioxidant, rasayana.
 - Uses: Immunity booster, digestion, hair and skin health, component of Triphala.
 6. **Guduchi (Giloy)** — *Tinospora cordifolia* | Parts: stem, leaves
 - Actions: Immunomodulatory, antipyretic, hepatoprotective.
 - Uses: Chronic fever, immune support, detoxification, diabetes adjunct.
 7. **Ginger (Shunthi/Ardra)** — *Zingiber officinale* | Parts: rhizome
 - Actions: Carminative, digestive stimulant, anti-emetic, anti-inflammatory.
 - Uses: Nausea, indigestion, cough, joint pain, colds.
 8. **Garlic (Lashuna)** — *Allium sativum* | Parts: bulb
 - Actions: Antimicrobial, hypolipidemic, cardiogenic.
 - Uses: Hypertension adjunct, cholesterol control, infections, respiratory conditions.
 9. **Shatavari** — *Asparagus racemosus* | Parts: root
 - Actions: Female tonic, galactagogue, adaptogen.
 - Uses: Reproductive health in women, lactation support, digestive issues.
 10. **Licorice (Yashtimadhu)** — *Glycyrrhiza glabra* | Parts: root
 - Actions: Demulcent, anti-inflammatory, adrenal tonic.
 - Uses: Coughs, peptic ulcers, stress support, flavoring in formulations.
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11. **Brahmi** — *Bacopa monnieri* | Parts: whole herb
 - Actions: Nootropic, nervine tonic, memory enhancer.
 - Uses: Memory and concentration support, anxiety, cognitive decline adjunct.
 12. **Haritaki** — *Terminalia chebula* | Parts: fruit
 - Actions: Mild laxative, rejuvenative, digestive regulator.
 - Uses: Constipation, rejuvenation (rasayana), component of Triphala.
 13. **Bibhitaki** — *Terminalia bellirica* | Parts: fruit
 - Actions: Astringent, laxative, respiratory support.
 - Uses: Respiratory ailments, digestive balance, component of Triphala.
 14. **Black Pepper (Maricha)** — *Piper nigrum* | Parts: fruit
 - Actions: Carminative, enhances bioavailability, digestive stimulant.

- Uses: Improves absorption of herbs (e.g., with turmeric), digestive complaints.

15. Long Pepper (Pippali) — *Piper longum* | Parts: fruit

- Actions: Digestive stimulant, expectorant, bioavailability enhancer.
- Uses: Respiratory disorders, digestive weakness, part of classical formulas.

16. Cardamom (Ela) — *Elettaria cardamomum* | Parts: seeds

- Actions: Carminative, aromatic, digestive and urinary tonic.
- Uses: Indigestion, bad breath, flavoring and mild diuretic.

17. Cinnamon (Tvak/Dalchini) — *Cinnamomum verum* | Parts: bark

- Actions: Carminative, blood sugar moderating, antimicrobial.
- Uses: Digestive discomfort, mild hypoglycemic adjunct, flavoring.

18. Curry Leaf (Karuveppilai) — *Murraya koenigii* | Parts: leaves

- Actions: Digestive, antioxidant, hypolipidemic.
- Uses: Improves digestion, hair and skin care, culinary herb with medicinal benefits.

19. Bael (Bilva) — *Aegle marmelos* | Parts: fruit, leaves

- Actions: Astringent, digestive, antidiarrheal.
- Uses: Diarrhea, dysentery, digestive disorders.

20. Moringa (Drumstick/ Moringa oleifera) — Parts: leaves, pods

- Actions: Highly nutritious, antioxidant, anti-inflammatory.
- Uses: Nutritional supplement, anemia support, general tonic, anti-inflammatory.

21. Sarpagandha (Rauwolfia) — *Rauwolfia serpentina* | Parts: root

- Actions: Antihypertensive, sedative (potent alkaloids).
- Uses: Historically used for high blood pressure and mental agitation (use under supervision).

22. Clove (Lavanga) — *Syzygium aromaticum* | Parts: flower bud

- Actions: Analgesic, antimicrobial, carminative.
- Uses: Toothache oil, digestive aid, antimicrobial preparations.

23. Fenugreek (Methi) — *Trigonella foenum-graecum* | Parts: seeds

- Actions: Galactagogue, hypoglycemic, anti-inflammatory.
- Uses: Lactation support, blood sugar support, digestive tonic.

24. **Fennel (Saunf)** — *Foeniculum vulgare* | Parts: seeds

- Actions: Carminative, galactagogue, digestive.
- Uses: Post-meals digestion, infant colic (as decoction), lactation.

25. **Coriander (Dhania)** — *Coriandrum sativum* | Parts: seeds, leaves

- Actions: Digestive, carminative, cooling.
- Uses: Digestive discomfort, culinary and medicinal cooling agent.

26. **Sandalwood (Chandan)** — *Santalum album* | Parts: wood, oil

- Actions: Cooling, astringent, antiseptic.
- Uses: Skin care, cooling pastes, religious and therapeutic applications.

27. **Aloe vera (Kumari)** — *Aloe vera* | Parts: gel, juice

- Actions: Demulcent, wound healing, laxative (outer leaf resin).
- Uses: Skin burns, wound healing, topical cosmetics, mild constipation (with care).

28. **Kutki (Picroliv)** — *Picrorhiza kurroa* | Parts: root

- Actions: Hepatoprotective, bitter tonic.
- Uses: Liver disorders, fever, digestive bitterness for appetite stimulation.

29. **Manjistha** — *Rubia cordifolia* | Parts: root, rhizome

- Actions: Blood purifier, astringent, lymphatic tonic.
- Uses: Skin disorders, blood purification, urinary tract support.

30. **Vidanga** — *Embelia ribes* | Parts: fruit

- Actions: Anthelmintic, antimicrobial.
- Uses: Expulsion of intestinal worms, parasitic infections.

31. **Shankhapushpi** — *Evolvulus alsinoides* (or *Convolvulus pluricaulis*) | Parts: whole herb

- Actions: Nootropic, nervine tonic, calming.
- Uses: Memory, sleep support, anxiety reduction.

32. **Kutaja (Kurchi)** — *Holarrhena antidysenterica* | Parts: bark

- Actions: Astringent, antidiarrheal.
- Uses: Chronic diarrhea, dysentery, bowel disorders.

33. **Bhringraj** — *Eclipta prostrata* | Parts: whole plant

- Actions: Hepatoprotective, hair tonic, nervine.
- Uses: Hair loss, liver support, scalp oils.

34. **Nirgundi** — *Vitex negundo* | Parts: leaves, roots

- Actions: Analgesic, anti-inflammatory, expectorant.
- Uses: Joint pain, respiratory complaints, topical analgesic.

35. **Ashoka** — *Saraca asoca* | Parts: bark, flowers

- Actions: Uterine tonic, astringent.
- Uses: Menstrual disorders, uterine health, dysmenorrhea.

36. **Camphor (Kapoora)** — *Cinnamomum camphora* | Parts: wood, oil

- Actions: Rubefacient, ruborant, inhalation stimulant.
- Uses: Topical for pain, inhalation for nasal congestion (small amounts), spiritual uses.

37. **Guggulu** — *Commiphora mukul* | Parts: resin

- Actions: Lipid-lowering, anti-inflammatory, analgesic.
- Uses: Joint disorders, obesity adjunct, lipid management (traditional use).

38. **Musta** — *Cyperus rotundus* | Parts: rhizome

- Actions: Carminative, digestive, astringent.
- Uses: Digestive weakness, diarrhea, menstrual regulation.

39. **Vidari** — *Pueraria tuberosa* | Parts: tuber

- Actions: Aphrodisiac, rejuvenative, nutritive.
- Uses: Reproductive tonic, general weakness, convalescence.

40. **Patha** — *Cissampelos pareira* (and related species) | Parts: root, stem

- Actions: Antimalarial, antipyretic, diaphoretic.
- Uses: Fever management, digestive complaints, traditional febrile conditions.

41. **Sesame (Til)** — *Sesamum indicum* | Parts: seeds, oil

- Actions: Nutritive, oleaginous, nourishing.
- Uses: Oil massage (abhyanga), nutritional oil, skin health.

42. **Saffron (Kesar)** — *Crocus sativus* | Parts: stigma

- Actions: Antidepressant, digestive stimulant, antioxidant.
- Uses: Mood support, culinary tonic, part of tonic formulations.

43. **Kalmegh (Andrographis)** — *Andrographis paniculata* | Parts: whole plant

- Actions: Bitter, hepatoprotective, immune stimulant.
- Uses: Fever, liver support, infections (supportive).

44. **Jatamansi** — *Nardostachys jatamansi* | Parts: root

- Actions: Nervine, sedative, calming.
- Uses: Insomnia, anxiety, nervous disorders, brain tonic.

45. **Tagara** — *Valeriana wallichii* | Parts: root

- Actions: Sedative, nervine tonic.
- Uses: Anxiety, sleep disorders, calming preparations.

46. **Kapikacchu (Mucuna)** — *Mucuna pruriens* | Parts: seed

- Actions: Nervine tonic, dopaminergic (levodopa-containing)
- Uses: Parkinson's adjunct (traditional use), male reproductive tonic (use under supervision).

47. **Khadira** — *Acacia catechu* | Parts: heartwood

- Actions: Astringent, antimicrobial.
- Uses: Oral care, digestive astringent, topical applications.

48. **Shallaki (Salai/Guggul commixture)** — *Boswellia serrata* | Parts: resin

- Actions: Anti-inflammatory, analgesic.
- Uses: Joint pain, osteoarthritis support, topical liniments.

49. **Karanja** — *Pongamia pinnata* | Parts: seeds, oil

- Actions: Antiseptic, insecticidal, dermatological.
- Uses: Skin conditions, topical oil for wounds, insect repellent properties.

50. **Asafoetida (Hing)** — *Ferula assafoetida* | Parts: resin

- Actions: Carminative, antispasmodic, digestive.
- Uses: Flatulence, colic, added to food as digestive aid and microbial support.

DAŚA PUSHPAM – Ten Sacred Flowers of Kerala

The *Daśa Pushpam* (“Ten Flowers”) are **ten sacred herbs** believed to promote **health, longevity, and spiritual well-being**.

Traditionally worn or used during **Onam, Thiruvathira**, and other festivals; they are also used in **Ayurvedic formulations**.

No.	Sanskrit Name	Malayalam Name	English / Botanical Name	Ayurvedic / Spiritual Significance & Medicinal Use
1	Karuka	കറുക (Karuka)	<i>Cynodon dactylon</i> – Bermuda Grass	Sacred grass used in rituals; cooling, hemostatic, diuretic.
2	Muyal Chevi	മുയൽച്ചെവി (Muyalchevi)	<i>Emilia sonchifolia</i> – Lilac Tassel Flower	Used for fever, eye disorders, and wound healing.
3	Poovamkurunnila	പൂവങ്കുറുന്നില (Poovamkurunnila)	<i>Vernonia cinerea</i>	Antipyretic, detoxifier, used in fevers and piles.
4	Uzhinja	ഉഴിഞ്ഞ (Uzhinja)	<i>Cardiospermum halicacabum</i> – Balloon Vine	Rheumatic pains, joint inflammation, nervous disorders.
5	Kayyonni	കയ്യോണി (Kayyonni)	<i>Eclipta alba</i> – False Daisy / Bhringraj	Hair tonic, liver protector, used for skin and eye disorders.
6	Thirutha	തിരുത (Thirutha)	<i>Ipomoea sepiaria</i>	Digestive, improves fertility (in traditional belief).
7	Uzhinjavarai	ഉഴിഞ്ഞവര (Uzhinjavara)	<i>Cleome viscosa</i> – Wild Mustard	Analgesic, antimicrobial, used in fevers and skin ailments.
8	Nilappana	നിലപ്പന (Nilappana)	<i>Curculigo orchoides</i> – Golden Eye Grass	Aphrodisiac, rejuvenative, improves vitality.
9	Cheroola	ചെറുല (Cheroola)	<i>Aerva lanata</i> – Mountain Knot Grass	Diuretic, used in kidney stones, urinary disorders.
10	Krishna Tulasi	കൃഷ്ണതൂളസി (Krishna Tulasi)	<i>Ocimum tenuiflorum</i> – Holy Basil	Immunity booster, respiratory ailments, sacred herb.

□ Traditional belief:

Wearing or offering the *Daśa Pushpam* to deities during festivals symbolizes balance of the **five elements (Pancha Mahabhutas)** within the body. It's also believed to **protect from seasonal diseases** and **enhance spiritual purity**.

DAŚA MŪLAM – Ten Medicinal Roots

The *Daśa Mūlam* (“Ten Roots”) form the **foundation of many classical Ayurvedic formulations**, especially **Dashamoola Kashayam**, **Dashamoola Arishta**, and other *Rasayanas*. They are divided into **two groups** – *five big roots (Bṛhat Pañcamūla)* and *five small roots (Laghu Pañcamūla)*.

I. Brihat Panchamoola (The Five Major Roots)

No.	Sanskrit Name	Malayalam Name	English / Botanical Name	Significance / Use
1	Bilva	വേല (Vilvam)	<i>Aegle marmelos</i>	Digestive, antidiarrhoeal, sacred to Lord Shiva.
2	Agnimantha	അഗ്നിമന്ദം (Agnimandham)	<i>Clerodendrum phlomidis</i>	Anti-inflammatory, improves digestion.
3	Shyonaka	സയോനകം (Syonakam)	<i>Oroxylum indicum</i>	Respiratory ailments, analgesic.
4	Gambhari	ഗംബാരി (Gambhari)	<i>Gmelina arborea</i>	Rejuvenative, tonic, used in fevers.
5	Patala	പാതാളം (Patala)	<i>Stereospermum suaveolens</i>	Respiratory diseases, anti-inflammatory.

II. Laghu Panchamoola (The Five Minor Roots)

No.	Sanskrit Name	Malayalam Name	English / Botanical Name	Significance / Use
6	Shalaparni	ശലപർണി (Salaparnni)	<i>Desmodium gangeticum</i>	Tonic, improves strength and immunity.
7	Prishnaparni	പുഷ്പർണി (Prishnaparnni)	<i>Uraria picta</i>	Promotes tissue repair, analgesic.
8	Brihati	കാട്ടവഴുതന (Kattavazhuthan)	<i>Solanum indicum</i>	Cough, asthma, anti-inflammatory.
9	Kantakari	കാട്ടവാഴുതന / ചുട്ടവഴുതന (Kattavazhuthan)	<i>Solanum xanthocarpum</i>	Respiratory disorders, anti-allergic.
10	Gokshura	നേർന്നറിഞ്ചി (Nerinjil)	<i>Tribulus terrestris</i>	Urinary tonic, aphrodisiac, diuretic.

The Three Fruits in Tri Phala

Sanskrit Name	Malayalam Name	English / Botanical Name	Main Ayurvedic Action
Amalaki (Āmalaka)	നെല്ലി (Nelli)	<i>Phyllanthus emblica</i> – Indian Gooseberry	Rich in Vitamin C, rejuvenative (<i>Rasayana</i>), digestive, anti-aging.
Haritaki (Haritaki)	കടുകൈ (Kadukkai)	<i>Terminalia chebula</i>	Mild laxative, digestive tonic, detoxifier.
Bibhitaki (Bibhitaki)	വിഭിമല (Vimma / Vibhithaki)	<i>Terminalia bellirica</i>	Respiratory support, detoxifying, balances Kapha and Pitta.